

On
the Concept, Nature,
and Essence of Philosophy.

A Presentation of
the Propaedeutic of Philosophy.

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Preface.

Had I not, up to now, let every writing of mine that has come forward independently in the literature be accompanied by a preface—not exactly because I have expressly reckoned such a thing among the proper appointments of a book, but because each time it has felt natural to me—I should this time have been inclined to dispense with any preface at all, since I had nothing to say that could be its subject. For the truth is that I would rather have refrained from expressly declaring that what several of my readers will perhaps expect to find stated here I mean to leave to them to settle for themselves. I mean this: in what relation the present writing stands to my book *Om Erkjendelse og Granskning* [On Cognition and Inquiry], published at the close of the year 1821. If I am to declare myself on the matter—for how I intend to use both writings in my lectures on the propaedeutic of philosophy [Philosophiens Propædeutik] does not belong here to explain—then, so far as the public is concerned, I would say nothing more than this: I could wish that, in its relation to the present book, the reader would regard that earlier one as though it were by another author, one whom I had drawn upon and to whom I had therefore often referred, while yet having a different object before me than he. For in that earlier work the object is science [Videnskab] and scientific study in general, and it is offered as an introduction to academic study at large. Here, by contrast, I have had philosophy in particular before me, and have therefore had more to enter into with respect to *this* than had come forward in that other work. —Finally, I ask that among the errata [Rettelser], those marked **NB** in particular may be heeded.

Copenhagen, the 28th of October 1843.

Sibbern.

Preliminary Remarks.

§ 1.

What is to be undertaken here, and where we set out from.

It is the concept, nature, and essence of philosophy that we shall here seek to clarify for ourselves. We cannot, then, confine ourselves to the question: What is meant by philosophy? but have to do with the far more telling question: What is philosophy? Yet we must of course, straightaway and from the very first, take account of the word's meaning, attending to what is called philosophy—and has through the course of history been so called, and has asserted itself under that name. For although the concept we are to seek to give is to be developed and determined as reflection on the matter itself demands, still the question—whether what is thereby set up corresponds to what one calls philosophy, or whether perhaps, with all the validity it may have in and for itself, it is something quite other than what one has in view by the word philosophy—can only be settled by taking into consideration the meaning with which this name passes and holds good. By the name, the object to be spoken of is pointed out, and one must from the first take care not to end up speaking of some other object instead of this one. It is most correct, then, to set out from a given representation [Forestilling] of what philosophy is—a given meaning of the word.

But the matter itself, thus pointed to by the name and thereby lifted out for us, we must then surely consider entirely as it wills to be seen, and must pursue it through its whole consequence, so that the concept, further on, cannot be bound to, nor in its whole carrying-through be conditioned by, that given representation.

In this way we do indeed come to consider philosophy in philosophy's own light, and thus come to lay our own philosophy at the foundation; for we are now to philosophize our way to the cognition [Erkjendelse] we seek, and in all philosophizing philosophy at once asserts itself. But this circularity is a consequence of the whole position of the matter; for philosophy is but one member within the world-totality [Verdenstotalitet] which philosophy itself—according to the concept of it that we must presuppose as given—is to clarify for us.

Note 1. There naturally arises here the question whether the concept of philosophy ought not to be treated in two quite different places: first, in the considerations introductory to philosophy, where the philosophical undertaking cannot of course be dealt with without laying at

its foundation a concept of what philosophy is; —and second, in the very midst of philosophy's system, once the speculative fundamental cognition [Grunderkjendelse] has been so far attained and developed that philosophy—stepping forward as a co-engaging member in the spiritual life unfolding in consciousness—comes to be considered from the speculative—more precisely a psycho-biological—standpoint. One readily sees that, although philosophy would lead us back to the first fundamental moments and beginning (*initia*) of all things, it nevertheless itself belongs in the very midst of the world's course, where it can first arise in the higher life of consciousness, or in the midst of the sphere of spirituality, and must then show itself as an essential principal moment in the totality of spiritual life. The question of philosophy's proper essence [Væsen] belongs, then, there where poetry, morality, and religiosity too are to constitute themselves for us in their essential belonging-together with the totality of spiritual life. —

The question then naturally arises whether we ought not to distinguish, from this spirit-philosophical and properly speculative consideration of philosophy's essence, another, preliminary one belonging to a mere introduction to philosophy—which we might then call the merely propaedeutic, and which would at the same time be called the merely explicative. This one would merely pursue the given concept of philosophy through all its consequence and thereafter determine and expound it, whereas the other would let philosophy itself constitute itself for us and thereby show itself in its proper essence. This last would then be the one which, if the very expressive designation the philosophy of philosophy is to be adopted, would have to be furnished with that name.

Yet to such a merely propaedeutic exposition of the concept of philosophy we neither can nor will here confine ourselves, nor keep it separated from the speculative; for it is philosophy itself—not the concept that has formed about it—that we have before us here, and the clarification of philosophy, if it is to be complete, cannot rest at that merely propaedeutic level.

In the meantime we must surely seek constantly to remain aware how far our concept, as it more and more determines and develops itself for us, remains within the domain [Gebeet] of the merely propaedeutic—so that it can be set up as valid with respect to the various philosophical parties (Platonists, Skeptics, Kantians, Lockians, and so forth), and can thus be laid at the foundation in the history of philosophy—and how far, on the other hand, it goes further, and so is already developed according to the dictate of a definite philosophical fundamental view [Grundanskuelse].

Note 2. One will readily see that it would be altogether inappropriate to give the first and fundamental part of philosophy itself—which Hegel has called Logic—the name of the philosophy of philosophy, as some have done. Hegel, too, is very far from having been able to give any occasion for this, since with him the philosophy of philosophy—though this name is not found in him—appears at the close of the third and last part of his whole system.

Note 3. Concerning the expression *nature and essence* and its relation to the expression *concept*, be it noted that what is here most immediately and first sought is the concept of philosophy and

its exact determination, but that this concept is then to unfold itself for us, or to step out into the whole sum-total [Indbegreb] of its consequence, or into its whole content—which is what we have in view by the expression *nature and essence*. (I refer here to my *Logik*, § 35.)

§ 2.

A survey of the whole course of what follows.

If, then, we ask first of all: What does one understand by philosophy?—whereby we are only to indicate provisionally just so much that we may know with certainty what it is that is to be treated, but must also at once come to indicate the first points to which we have to direct our attention—then we note that the received concept implies that philosophy is to aim at a certain fundamental cognition [Grunderkjendelse] serving for a deeper clarification of the whole of existence [Tilværelse], but that it is to form itself through thinking and reflection, and thus to become a cognition that is to be aware of its own inner groundedness and able to give an account of it. In this way, then, we come to let our consideration take the following course:

First and foremost we take into consideration that 1) philosophy is a whole body of cognizing [Indbegreb af Erkjenden], and we therefore consider the nature and essence of cognition in general.

Next we observe that, since philosophy aims at a certain deeper fundamental cognition that looks toward the last or innermost fundamental relations [Grundforhold]—yet such a cognition shows itself as philosophy only when it comes forward as sprung from rational cognition [Fornufterkjendelse], and especially only when investigation [Efterforskning] or inquiry [Randsagelse] has thereby been set in motion—we are hereby led to consider the endeavor of cognition in general in its transition from its first principal stage, the stage of first, immediate cognizing, to its second principal stage, the mediated but at the same time higher stage of cognizing called forth by the spirit of inquiry [Randsagelsesaand]—the stage at which cognition becomes a cognizing according to insight, and at the same time—since here testing must take place, an account must be rendered, grounds come under consideration, and groundedness is brought to light and made good—a cognition in force of grounds [i Kraft af Grunde]; which then lets us see philosophy as that which 2) is a whole body of intelligent and rational cognizing.

To this attaches, further, the observation that, since this whole body must form a well-connected totality [Heelhed], philosophy in its carrying-through and execution must become 3) a scientific cognition—whereby we are brought to consider science [Videnskab] and scientific character [Videnskabelighed] in general.

But since—according to the received concept—not all scientific cognizing is philosophy, then, by asking ourselves what sort of science it is in which philosophy consists, we come to become aware that the endeavor to press through to the grounds cannot but lead to the forming of 4) a *science* that in a certain *all-comprehending manner* aims at ultimate grounds and an ultimate fundamental cognition, and that it is this above all that one has in view when one speaks of philosophy; and here, when the question is now raised whether it is the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of all cognition, or of the whole of existence, that are thereby meant, it will appear that—although a twofold principal task [Hovedopgave] for philosophy has in this respect formed, and had to form—it is nevertheless in the end only 5) the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of *existence*, or as one is wont to say, of *all things*, in the finding-out and cognition of which the all-comprehending fundamental cognition is to form, wherein philosophy consists.

This determination of the concept of philosophy, handed down from ancient times, from which we are thus brought to set out, shows us philosophy as that which comes forward over against, and in a certain opposition to, the sum-total of all that cognizing whereby everything is given us and presents itself to us—everything whose ultimate grounds and fundamental relations are now to be in question, and which we are accordingly prompted and called upon to gather for ourselves into a single overview.

In its pursuit through the various principal respects or principal directions, we shall next see the concept of philosophy lead to a whole cycle of conceptual determinations, which can be developed into a whole cycle of definitions.

Thereupon we shall proceed to consider philosophy in its execution. But when we now first take into consideration what ultimate grounds are, and how matters stand with our pressing toward them, the question of philosophy's foundation [Grundlag] and starting-point will prove to have to precede the question of the execution of philosophy's work—to which, then, once we have thereupon fully answered for ourselves the question what philosophy is, a consideration of philosophy's significance in the totality of existence will naturally be able to succeed.

With this, the course we shall take is fully indicated.

Note. It must be noted here at once—what will be more closely treated further on in its place—that alongside philosophy proper, of which alone there is question here, there is a whole body of sciences which, without being philosophy proper, are nevertheless also called philosophical, but which I, to distinguish them from the former (see further on, § 11), give the name of explicative philosophy, and to which I here pay no regard whatever.

Introductory Considerations.

On Cognition in General.

§ 3.

Philosophy is a) cognition. —The fundamental moments of all cognition.

All cognizing aims at an *is*, whereby something, in asserting itself in us, is posited by us as an objective [det Objective] to which we must ascribe validity, and which, insofar as it comes forward for us in this its validity, we call the true—which is then to be taken entirely as it gives itself to us, that is: shows itself to be.

Here, then, we see an opposition [Modsætning] between a self-conscious subjectivity and an objectivity subsisting independently of it—one which, moreover, comes forward for us not only from without but also from within. But cognition sets in only when this opposition is so overcome that what is comes forward for the subjectivity too exactly as it is, so that it comes to be for us—that is, is posited by us to be—just as it is in itself; whereby we come, in the very act of living in our own individual subsistence, at the same time to live in the fullness of objectivity, indeed of the true.

The mediating and unifying element between the true and the subjectivity—which latter shows itself at the same time as an individuality—is, on the side of the first, the determining necessity with which it asserts itself, and on the side of the subjectivity it is *partly* the latter's becoming-determined and the coming-to-consciousness that thereby sets in, which may be called a receiving (*scimus, quia accepimus*), *partly* the individual life's own doing that answers to that becoming-determined. —But this last is again partly one that aims merely at a directing of the mind [Sindshenvendelse], partly one that aims at inner subjective re-presentation and objectification. In the first we see a subjective reaction and response, called forth by the awakening power of the determining influence, that aims merely to make the reception deeper and fuller—both through an accompanying devotion and through a supervening recollection—as a care that the true may, in all its points and relations, come to its rightful full power in us, so that in each and all we may be determined wholly in accordance with the true's own bearing. In the subjective re-presentation and objectification, by contrast, we see a productivity springing from the individual life itself, which has its inner ground and mode of activity within itself, and now, as a producing doing, brings forth and constitutes within the subjective self-consciousness the inner presentation, in and through which the true

comes to be taken up into the subjective life. (And here, properly, it is first said: *scimus, quia facimus*. —For the rest I refer here to my work *Om Erkjend. og Granskn.*, §§ 1–3, as well as to my *Psychologie*.) But what makes it that in our own productivity we nonetheless have, not something merely subjective, but—by means of and through this merely subjective—the true itself, is the power with which the true so determines and governs the subjective life that creates and forms the representation, that it thereby at the same time presents itself as the valid for the self-conscious beholding.

Note 1. When we here speak of an “is,” we see here not only an opposition between an “is” and an “is-not,” but also an opposition between an “is” and a “shows itself” or “seems.” Hereupon one may at once ask whether this “seems” too must not be said to be, and conversely, whether an “is” can ever be anything other than a “shows itself.” Here it would be a matter of asking what that “is” really means; and when we then observe that we can in general have to do only with a being insofar as it asserts itself, but that now every seeming too asserts itself, then the question is whether there is here a differing self-assertion, and on what such difference rests—whereby a difference between a merely momentary and subjective and a more constant and objective self-assertion may perhaps be assumed, and within the latter there may again be distinguished a) a merely sporadic, b) a merely microcosmic, c) a macrocosmic validity, and only the last is to be acknowledged as the properly true one in the last instance. But here the consideration would arise that all apparent, all sporadic, all microcosmic self-assertion must in the end be grounded in the macrocosmic order of things, so that here it is to be noted that all that other self-assertion is seen in its true light—that is, in its proper being—only by being seen in its emergence from, and reducibility to, the macrocosmic order of things. —But all the considerations that might thus be called forth by reflection on that “is” do not belong here, but to the fundamental considerations of speculative philosophy itself. —This much is certain: that throughout all our striving for cognition, the opposition between an “is” and a “seems”—an “in itself” and a “not in itself”—and along with it the opposition between an objective and a subjective, so asserts itself that in the whole course of our cognizing, as in the whole of the rest of our life bound up with it, we cannot withdraw ourselves from it. And to this we hold ourselves here, where we have merely to expound the nature of cognition as it gives itself to us, and where we take without further ado the existence of a cognizing, with all the moments therein, as given—just as we take the existence of a philosophy as given—without entering here into the question of the proper reality of all cognition and all philosophy, which it belongs to speculative philosophy itself to decide. —The concept of cognition we have here given has plainly—this is still to be noted—validity even for one who would deny all our cognizing any true reality; for such a one too must nonetheless have a concept of cognition that he lays at the foundation, and it can only be the one given here; and one who would ascribe to all our cognizing only a certain subjective validity must still admit that cognition rests on the agreement of our representing with something that takes on the character

of an objective.

Note 2. As an “is” forms itself, intelligence at once intervenes, and a so-called category—or better, an a priori fundamental determination—asserts itself. Herewith cognition too at once comes forward as that which issues in a judging, whereby a something (as subject) comes forward as that which is something definite (the fundamental determination of whatness), and this what-it-is comes forward as an other, which is nonetheless, by the judging itself, made one with the former (as predicate). This fundamental nature of judging is expressed in the so-called principle of identity.

Note 3. The question arising here—how that productivity, having its inner ground and mode of activity, and hence also the regulative principle for it, within itself, nonetheless comes to present a real objective—is of speculative nature, and finds for us its answer in the Idea of a *harmonia originaria* between individuality and totality. The determining influence of the objective is indeed only an eliciting one, since it is the individual life itself that, by its own activity within the individuality’s circle of consciousness, brings about that whereby the objective is to become the cognized. But just as the whole individuality first comes forth at all through the total course of things, and becomes, in its whole existence, as that course brings it about, so too its whole organization—both in inner, psychic, and in outer respects—is constituted in such a way, answering to the totality, that every influence coming from the totality, whether it come from without or from the inner universal, calls forth its own determinate corresponding activity in the individual organization, or in the microcosm, and this so that it now, according to the latter’s own fundamental nature, leads precisely to such a certain determinate production that just that determinate objective is thereby represented by us. So that, although we constantly behold objects in our own soul, we nonetheless behold the actual objects as they are in themselves, because our inner representations become images of them, or counter-images to them, inasmuch as our inner life of consciousness—according to that inner harmony of its with the totality, when it (be it noted) is in its normal course—must each time bring forth, out of its own inner working, precisely that nerve-action, with corresponding representation-action, which produces just that representation which answers to the object. The individual organism, which contains within itself the real possibility of all possible representation-productions, is as it were calculated to work, at every point—that is, in every respect—in such accord or concordance with every influence coming from the side of the total, that the former each time produces precisely what the latter aims to call forth (as when an instrument, according to its own entire construction, renders—though in its own individual way—precisely the tone that is struck on another). We feel ourselves, however, in this not as related to mere counter-images, but as related to actual objects, because we here constantly feel our organism subjected to an affection which, coming from something other than ourselves, is what calls forth and compels that action and production of our own soul—so that the affection of our individual organism, or microcosm, distinguishes for us sensation from mere representation.

§ 4.

Philosophy is b) intelligent and rational cognizing. —The fundamental moments of cognition in their appearance as such. —Cognition as intelligent.

The individual life of consciousness, determined by the power of the objective, shows itself, insofar as it comes forward over against the objective, as that which is in itself free, carrying with it an inexhaustible possibility of acting in other ways than the way which the determining necessity each time brings with it. The necessity thus refers here to a freedom, and has such a freedom for its object, since it is precisely the in-itself-free (the in-itself-free imagination and reflection) that is bound by the necessity; and only thereby does cognition acquire the character of a cognizing, since only thereby does it show itself as an ascription of validity [Gyldighedstillæggelse]. [The true, too, comes forward as the valid and as that which is cognized in its validity only to the same degree as this free element, coming forward as such, then shows itself to be that which is determined and bound.]

But in the first natural cognizing, which forms itself of its own accord, and in which we on the whole comport ourselves as natural beings (cf. my *Psych.*, *ny Udarb.*, § 26), the opposition between the objective and the subjectivity, though it may show itself in particular cases, does not come forward in such a way that it wholly asserts itself as such. Cognition finds itself then, despite all the mediating element lying within it, at a first stage of immediacy, and the moments of cognition, though certainly present, are so lost in the cognizing as a whole that they do not come forward as such. But then neither does the true come forward for us in *its truth*, nor does it come to assert itself by its formally acknowledged validity.

In order for the true to attain such a higher governance, the individual life of consciousness lying on the side of the subjectivity must first come wholly forth into its freedom. And to this, too, the striving for cognition leads in its advance, in that we—whether by some other interest, or by mere desire to know [Videdrivt] and the higher life working itself forth through it—are moved to go beyond the immediately given, to seek other and more: either merely a) by looking further about us in the sphere opened to us, whereby not only the directing of the mind, that is, attention, becomes free, but also, as expectation sets in, the representation begins to find itself unbound; or else b) by asking after other and more than what is given in that sphere, because through it we find ourselves awakened to seek something such as that to which the given points—so that a spirit of inquiry [Randsagelsesaand] asserts itself, and scrutiny [Granskning]

or investigation [Efterforskning] comes forth, and now not only the representation, the imagination, but also the pursuit of relations and connections lying within it, or reflection, comes forward as such. —But the new that is now in this way formally sought is sought at the same time as the valid, and as answering to the investigation in such a way that that questioning can find itself satisfied; whereby one strives after a result by which the representing and pursuing that has become free—or has stepped forth into its freedom—can again be sufficiently determined and bound, with a necessity that is now also sought, and which, when found, will come to come forward as such.

But the necessity—together with the being-governed by, and being-at-home in, the power of the objective—that sets in in this way has then a different and freer character than that first immediate necessity. It now comes forward as necessity of understanding and reason [Forstands- og Fornuftnødvendighed], and we ourselves now show ourselves as beings of reason who ascribe validity because we acknowledge according to an express admission, assent, and approval grounded in insight; whereby the acknowledgment, or ascription of validity, too comes—stepping forth into its freedom—to show itself as such. For although at first it may be only new objects, of the same kind as those given in an immediate way, that are thus sought under a merely tracking observation, they must now not only show themselves to us as the ones we sought, but we must now also be assured that they are the right ones, and that we now objectify them to ourselves rightly, so that nothing else presents itself to us and is posited by us than the in-itself-valid, or that which *ought* to be posited. —But this then naturally has such a retroactive effect on what was earlier immediately assumed that it too can be drawn into the same consideration, so that *all* cognizing can become the object of a question as to its validity.

Cognition will in this way become one that we ourselves confirm in ourselves, in that we confirm ourselves in it, so that now the assurance too comes to show itself as such, and indeed as a potentiated assurance, or as an assurance of whose validity we are assured. —But certainly the uncertainty lying in the questioning may here too come forward in such a way that something doubting, dubitative, may set in, which is however overcome when a result is attained that becomes sufficiently satisfying.

Here, then, there emerges a properly mediated cognizing—mediated, namely, by thinking, and resting on thinking and the satisfaction of thinking—an intelligent cognizing, in the formation of which the fundamental demands originally lying in the pursuit of connection and relation that strives toward cognition, that is, in thinking itself (in the intelligence in the subject), are so in motion that it is in accordance with their satisfaction that insight, approval, and acknowledgment set in.

§ 5.

Continuation. What the intelligent cognizing aims at.

Such an intelligent cognizing forms itself, in all inquiry that reaches its goal, at least to this extent, that it is seen a) *that* something definite is to be assumed and ought to be posited. But if we ask whether also that b) *which* we cognize—the content of cognition—constitutes itself for us through thinking, that is, through necessity of understanding and reason, we note that this too is something to which thinking leads. We thus come to distinguish between 1) the affection-necessity that confirms itself by itself—though through the medium of thinking or intelligence—together with the cognizing that rests upon it, and 2) the necessity constituted by the consideration of understanding and reason *with respect to the assumed content itself*, together with the cognizing that rests upon this. In the first case the necessity is of that first immediate kind that preceded inquiry, and it asserts itself in the same way, save that we have now, through reflection, found ourselves entitled to grant it room and power. The validity of cognition here comes forward for us on the ground of a pursuit of relation and connection, and the acknowledgment, or ascription of validity, has its foundation in such a pursuit; but it does not yet assert itself in the constitution of cognition with respect to the cognized itself. [As when, by means of tests, one assures oneself that one has observed a phenomenon correctly.] In the second case, by contrast, that which is to be cognized is fixed and determined by the intelligence, so that cognition even takes on the appearance of being one that we ourselves constitute by our own thinking and determining—although here too we are determined, since here too that which must guide and determine this our constituting becomes the foundation. Only the last kind of cognizing can we properly call the intelligent cognizing, and it is then one that partly a) takes place in force of the pursuit of connection and relation, and partly b) consists in a cognition of the connections and relations themselves, together with what lies at the ground in or for them, which in them makes up the inner constitutive element.

Note 1. It will easily be seen that, while under the first case we reckon in the reflection that determines us to ascribe validity to a felt affection-necessity, the reflection on the groundedness of this ascription of validity—when this is now regarded as the object of our questioning—will, by contrast, carry us over into the second of the two cases here distinguished.

Note 2. We note further that there may be cases here in which a cognition of a “what” can, together with its “that,” constitute itself for us in an intelligent way, without our having penetrated into the object’s “how.” Thus the validity of our faith in a governance [Styrelse], and the validity

of our living in this faith, can prove themselves to us in an intelligent way—and this so that the very cognition of the existence of such a governance constitutes itself for us through thinking, without an insight into that governance itself being thereby formed.

Note 3. Concerning the expression necessity of understanding and reason, by which the necessity we may also call the intellectual is here designated, be it noted that the double expression has come in because here one is to think most immediately of the understanding (*intellectus*), as that which enters into the pursuit of connection and relation—the both objective and subjective pursuit of thought that here takes place, and which leads to insight, and so also to understanding (*intelligere*); but that then, when the acknowledgment takes place as such, so that there is posited what we see we must, and indeed *ought* to, posit, the sense for the all-valid in its all-validity is in motion in the manner of recollection—that is, reason.

But now the objective can also show itself to us through—and address us through—the beneficently satisfying that it can have for us, and can now assert itself in us, in its validity, by this way too. We then come to be moved by it in such a way that we attach ourselves to it, give ourselves over to it, and love it; whereby, once an acknowledgment of it also develops, a quite different kind of cognition sets in than cognition in force of insight and acknowledged groundedness—namely the one I have elsewhere called the sympathetic [sympathetisk], and have presented as the third principal kind of cognizing, in the threefold division: a) the immediately beholding, b) the intelligent, c) the sympathetic cognizing—to which last belong partly the aesthetic, partly faith and what may be placed together with it. See my *Psych., ny Udarb.*, § 33, p. 130; cf. *Maanedskr. f. Liter.* 1838, no. 6.

Note 5. But this threefold division we must here take into consideration in yet another respect. We have come to see how cognition, from its first principal stage—that of immediacy, or the stage of first immediate cognizing—passes over to assume a new character, by coming forward as the mediated, but at the same time intelligent and thereby higher, cognizing called forth by the spirit of inquiry. But now the question must arise how this stands to that sympathetic cognizing, which likewise shows itself as mediated in such a way that in it too the subjectivity comes forward as such over against the objective. We note, then, that this last is here to be reckoned with that first immediate cognizing; for although, in comparison with the immediately beholding cognizing, it shows itself to be more mediated—and so far to be set alongside the intelligent—it nonetheless, just as much as the immediately beholding, forms itself prior to all inquiry and testing, and yields something that is only by the intelligent cognizing to be made the object of a question as to its validity and its content. —Over against the intelligent cognizing—which, as we shall see more closely further on, can also be called the rational—we find another, at which we do not arrive through a rational striving, but which forms itself prior to it, and has its own foundation, independent of the rational (by which we mean the rational as it comes forward in its rationality). This other cognizing we may then call the extrarational or preterrational

(because we do not have it by way of inquiry and rendering of account, or by grounds that have presented themselves to us as such, but obtain it in another way). To such extrarational cognizing now belongs both that which owes its existence solely to outer sensation, together with what is to be placed alongside it (to which the intuition of space and time belongs), and also the whole sympathetic cognizing, which likewise forms and maintains itself outside that rationality. All such extrarational cognizing is also, as regards its arising, by its nature more dependent on immediate influence, affection, than the intelligent. For the rest, we also find in the sphere of the intelligent much that forms itself in the manner of immediacy; and it must be noted generally that humanity, especially among the cultivated nations, now appropriates in the manner of immediacy, or of itself—that is, without express reflection and deliberation—much toward which one had at first only slowly worked one's way. This, especially as regards the music of the ancients, has been elucidated by the Reverend Pastor Bindesbøl in his review of Dr. Bojesen's doctoral dissertation *de harmonica scientia Græcorum* (1833) in *Maanedskr. f. Liter.* 1837, 8th number; cf. the introduction to Dr. Bojesen's school program 1843, *de tonis s. harmoniis Græcorum*, p. 6.

Note 6. The question that here naturally arises, when we look to human striving as striving and to its course and fate in humanity—why, then, not all cognizing, including the deeper and higher, gives itself to us in the simpler, more direct, and more immediate way, as the immediacy of genius nonetheless shows to happen in individual cases in the higher spheres—has been treated by me in my work *Om Erkj. og Gr.* in the Note to § 4, pp. 32–36, with which what is set forth in my *Pathologie*, § 23, pp. 55–56, may be compared. But I will here return to this question, in order to give a more comprehensive answer to it than was there given.

Three things are here to be looked to: We note that we must not only a) work our way slowly, through much investigation and exertion, toward the higher cognizing, but that the way even b) passes through much doubt and uncertainty, indeed c) opens such a possibility of error that this has in many ways become actual; and we now ask why the whole state of affairs is such. To this the answer is: a) that it thus belongs to the individual spiritual course of development on the one side, and to the full objectification of the objective on the other, so that both the full advance of personality on its side and the advance of the realm of the objective on its side must bring it about so; and that, as regards b) doubt in particular, the full self-confirmation and confirmation of the matter can take place only in this way, point by point; and that c) the possibility of error could be nothing other than a direct consequence of the whole state of affairs, since this entailed that reflection and imagination had to become free and to assert themselves in their freedom, in order that a life in intelligence and freedom might develop and form itself—but that such a life was in turn the necessary foundation for the development of a realm in spirit and love.

But finally it remains to be noted that, when one looks to the condition of humanity as it actually shows itself to be, it must surely be taken into account that the general human sinfulness, and the abnormality or aberration and disturbance bound up with it in the whole of human life, could not but intervene inhibitingly, disturbingly, and distortingly in the human striving for cognition, and indeed in the whole course and manner of cognition—and that this must be taken into account when we set actuality before our eyes and find it full of uncertainty, doubt, and error.

§ 6.

Cognition as rational, working toward an ultimate foundation.

Insofar as the questioning and inquiry that set in lead to the testing under which we render account of the validity of the new becoming-determined that is to set in, the determining shows itself as a ground, or as that whereby we, in rendering account, find ourselves determined to assume what we assume (*ratio*); and insofar as such a determining takes place point by point in the whole of the new cognizing now forming itself, there set in here, in a continuous way, grounds without cease (*rationes*), and cognition then shows itself as a cognition in force of grounds—and indeed as one that asserts itself through the consciousness, now coming forward as such, of its groundedness. The intelligent cognizing then shows itself, with respect both to the rendering of account and to the consideration of grounds that here takes place, as a rational one. The in-itself grounded and valid is then assumed only insofar as it has shown itself to us in its groundedness, and thereby in its truth.

But when grounds are sought and pursued, and a full assurance is to be sought in groundedness, then one must go back to ultimate grounds and an ultimate foundation—which is then thereafter to be regarded as the first foundation, and the grounds as the first grounds for the whole cognizing, which only thereby becomes thoroughly rational.

Note. The in-itself-valid true thereby comes—as it now steps forward in its acknowledged validity and truth—to rule with a higher power, in that it comes to rule as that to which we ourselves render our homage. —But the resisting subjective too is thereby lifted to a higher stage; for since cognition here proceeds from inquiry and testing, and the agreement and assent that follow from them, the subjectivity comes to move with freedom and with harmony in that sphere of higher necessity and being-governed. —The governed is now ensouled, inspirited.

§ 7.

Philosophy is c) scientific cognition. On science and scientific character in general.

If we consider more closely what grounds are, we see that—since they consist in that which brings it about that, when something definite is given, some definite other must also be, or be posited to be—they point back to a certain connection, and this again to a certain fundamental connection, according to which it is that with or from the one the other follows; so that the cognition of grounds must become a cognition of connection, and cognition in force of grounds must become a cognizing in force of the pursuit of connection. But thus the rational cognizing must lead to the whole body of cognitions one has becoming a well-connected one, in which each particular, as an account is given of it, is at the same time seen in its being taken up into a forming totality of cognition. Hereby cognition becomes scientific, and the whole body of cognition becomes science in the proper sense. —Hereby a plurality of cognitions—which, insofar as they come forward each on its own with its determinateness, make up the detail [Detail] of the science—orders itself together in such a way that a well-connected whole, or a system, forms itself; in which, however, the cognizing itself, the very insight and rationality according to which every particular is determined and the whole system is ordered and formed, is so much the main thing that everything depends on such a thing—which we now call sometimes the spirit of the science, sometimes its Idea—coming to stir and live in that totality of cognitions; in which, however, every particular must now come forth each on its own, so that the detail of the science, by an intelligent and rational pursuit of the matter's own detail, unfolds itself into a whole body of concepts and conceptual determinations, and the system shows itself as a whole of conceptual cognizing answering to the objectively given whole.

Note. To the threefold division here named as lying in science as such—a) spirit or Idea, b) system, and c) detail—there will further be added, when one looks to the so-called treatment of a science (both in the study that is to lead to it and in the communication of it to others), method [Methode], which may then be regarded partly in a subjective-logical, partly in a didactic respect. But herewith there is no longer question of the matter itself, but only of our endeavor of cognition and presentation. Concerning both that objective threefold division and this subjective element, I refer for the rest to my book *Om Erkj. og Granskn.*, where there is also (in § 17) discussion of the inner organic relation of reciprocal action among Idea, system, and detail. Only on this relation of reciprocal action will I dwell somewhat here, and I note the following about it:

We find ourselves in the midst of a great totality of objects and relations, and this not only in the outer respect, but also with respect to the realm of intelligence and of the higher manifestations and workings within us. Our life forms itself under these conditions in a sporadic way, from innumerable points that assert themselves, each

point in its own way; and to this there corresponds a whole body of observations or remarks, each of which then comes forward with its own—actual, or at least presumed—validity. Such observations can further be made deliberately at innumerable points, since each time that is observed and apprehended which each time comes forward. Only when a whole body of such observations has been gathered can that spirit of pursuit begin to work which is to lead to the well-connected total cognition, to system and systematic insight. Here the isolated observation of every particular in its particularity will constantly assert its right, so that the systematic cognizing must become such as the detailed observing brings it about; but conversely the systematic insight will in turn have a determining, clarifying, purifying influence on the detailed observing. The whole will thus, in and for our cognizing, be determined by the detail, and the cognition of detail, together with the way of seeing and setting forth the detail, be in turn determined by the cognition of the whole.

But in the whole, as the gathering-together or coming-together of the manifold into unity, there must further reveal itself that in force of which both the particular is taken as it is taken—being in a determinate way taken up into the whole and ordered within it—and the whole is organized as it is thereupon carried out. And thus we come to something more deeply underlying: the, as it were, omnipresent fundamental cognition, which rises up beneath the whole observing and organizing, and now constitutes both the fundamentally determining and the fundamentally guiding, and yet at the same time itself only develops and takes on definite shape in the course of that striving. This we now call sometimes the Idea, sometimes the spirit in the science.

The Propaedeutic Concept of Philosophy and Its Exposition.

§ 8.

Philosophy aims d) at an all-comprehending fundamental cognition. The subjective principal task.

A whole body of cognitions can be intelligent and rational, and moreover so entirely scientific that it leads to the development of a proper science, without therefore being

philosophy—indeed without so much as coming into contact with philosophy, according to the prevailing concept of it, to which we here (in accordance with what was noted in § 1) have to hold ourselves. Of this we find telling proofs both in the natural sciences and in mathematics. The question then is what is peculiar to the science that is called philosophy.

We note first of all that philosophy is to lead us back to the ultimate grounds. But here the question now arises what is meant by this, and the following is then to be taken into consideration:

It was cognition that, under the rational striving, first and most immediately showed itself as that which passed over into becoming one that came to take place in force of grounds; it was cognition that was to show itself to us in its groundedness and validity, and thereby in its truth. So far, then, the grounds in question were grounds of knowing (*rationes cognoscendi*). Here the constant question is: what are we to assume and posit, and by what right do we each time assume what we assume and, according to this assuming, cognize; but the endeavor here presses toward an ultimate foundation.

By this we are now first and most immediately led to look to the first source or origin of cognitions—by which is meant that whereby they are given us, or which exercises the determining influence upon us. But here, in different spheres of cognition, a different kind of immediate determinateness comes forward, which in each sphere by itself yields something first, from which we, by pursuing the relations that show themselves therein, are led to more; and this more, when it now comes forward for us, either a) asserts itself by the same kind of immediate determining as that first, so that the mediating becomes merely a leading-on, or else b) shows itself as that which is assumed in an intelligent way on the ground of that first, or is assumed as something seen to have to be a consequence of it, even though this does not stand before us in the same immediate way as that first. In the first case the testing can aim only at whether we really are determined (affected) as it presents itself to us (whether we really do see, hear, and so on, this and that so and thus); in the second case the testing aims at that which is to be assumed in such a way that it must be seen to correspond to and agree with the grounding referred to it, so that here it is a question of intelligent satisfaction (for example, in determining the representation one is to form of the planetary system). See above, § 5.

But of a quite different nature is the pursuit and the question concerning the validity of our cognizing, when the dubitative that may here arise, and the problematic (especially under great collisions, where from one side one thing, from another another, seems bent on asserting itself), lead to asking after the validity of all human cognizing—indeed after

the groundedness of all assurance whatsoever—so that the reliability of all those relatively first sources, and the validity of their authority, indeed the objective truth of everything given through them, are made the object of a question and a consideration that then becomes so all-comprehending that an ultimate foundation for all cognizing as cognizing, or for all assuming and ascription of validity whatsoever, and an all-comprehending fundamental cognition in this respect, are demanded. But one easily sees that then there is no longer question of grounds of knowing, but of all cognition's own groundedness and validity, so that here there is even question of something other and more than what we may call the *universam cognoscendi rationem*, when by this, namely, we mean the fundamental nature and constitution of all cognizing. Hereby we pass over into the domain of philosophy; indeed both the nature of the matter itself and a glance at the whole history of philosophy must lead us to set up the question here arising as one of philosophy's principal tasks, which we will then call philosophy's subjective principal task. But of this we shall speak further on, where it will appear that this task is taken up into a larger one.

§ 9.

The objective principal task. —Philosophy aims e) at the ultimate grounds of existence.

For the whole rationality in our cognizing aims at more than merely the groundedness and validity of cognitions. It aims at the fundamental relations of the objects themselves, and thus also at these objects' own grounds, in that we strive that what each point in existence itself is grounded in may show itself to us. For our whole endeavor of cognition aims at our being able, in and through cognition, fully to appropriate and to live our way into objectivity; but then we must enter into the connection and relations in all that is given, so that everything therein may show itself to us, each in its significance within the totality. And thus we come not only to call ourselves to account with respect to our apprehension of the objective, but come also to call the objective itself to account at every point—to call the things themselves to account—that they may, as it were, give us a reckoning of what they themselves are grounded in, and how it stands with their fundamental relations. —But since we now also here strive to go to ultimate grounds and fundamental relations, we come—since the whole of existence asserts itself to us as forming a single whole—to strive after an all-comprehending fundamental cognition corresponding to it: not as an aggregate of several, but with inner unity and wholeness in itself.

And hereby we again pass into the domain of philosophy and meet its second principal task, which we will call the objective.

§ 10.

A propaedeutic definition of philosophy.

Of philosophy in general we may then say that it arises when the endeavor a) to go to the ultimate grounds also aims b) at becoming all-comprehending, and this in such a way that it would lead everything back to c) one universal foundation, so that one all-comprehending ultimate fundamental cognition may form itself. And herewith the first propaedeutic definition of philosophy is given.

But when we now add that philosophy, as we have seen, and as the history of philosophy too teaches, has from the first a twofold principal task—since both the question of the ultimate foundation and groundedness, reality and objectivity, truth and certainty of all our cognizing, and the question of the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of the things themselves, come forward as chief and fundamental questions—we come, by considering the relation of the two principal tasks to one another, to see that the subjective task is to be subsumed under the objective. For the ultimate ground and constitution of all our cognizing (*universa ratio cognoscendi*) must after all rest on our whole standing with respect to the objective, our whole incorporation into and fundamental relation to the totality that presents itself to us; so that, just as we find ourselves only as members and parts of a great whole, so too we must find our consciousness, and thus also our cognizing, so entering into this whole that our whole life of consciousness, with all our cognition in its wholeness, can become only one among the chief objects whose ultimate fundamental relations and fundamental essence are to be treated.

Thus our definition will determine itself more closely as follows: that we regard philosophy in general as that whose task it is, in an all-comprehending way, to press through to the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of the whole of existence, or of all things, in order, in force of the fundamental cognition thereby won, to clarify everything. —Philosophizing is then the thinking consideration, or pursuit of thought, in which partly a striving to reach such an ultimate—or, as it may in another respect also be called, first—fundamental cognition works itself forward, and partly such a fundamental cognition, insofar as it has formed itself, further seeks to assert itself.

Note 1. When we cognize all things in their ultimate grounds, we must also come to cognize our very cognizing—which belongs among these all things—in its ultimate groundedness. In

the total order of things in which we move, we find, among other things, cognizing beings; the existence of these, with the whole striving after cognition that appears in them, must then be grounded in this order of things, and must, as regards its nature and mode of existence and as regards its reality, rest upon it. —This too will be seen when the subjective principal task is pursued. Even the subjective-idealist solution of it—according to which it is assumed that the existence presenting itself to us has no proper objectivity, but has reality, validity, and existence only in and for our consciousness, or our knowing of and with ourselves—nonetheless turns, in seeking to determine the reality of our representing, on the question what we are to take the whole objectivity given to us to be; and when it teaches us that we live only in a world that presents itself to us—of whose reality, independently of this its self-presentation to us, we can never speak, since we can never have to do with anything other than what presents itself to us—it thereby nonetheless determines both our existence and the mode of existence of what we call the objective, or call the things over against us; and it does so in such a way that we nonetheless also find ourselves over against them, and so must reckon ourselves too among the totality of things; for “thing” here means in general only something that is spoken of and that can be the object of an assuming and judging. But cognition we nonetheless find again as something definite in the midst of that totality; and if this totality is only a system of necessary representations, then our endeavor of cognition finds itself nonetheless inserted as a member within this system of necessary representations. But the subjective principal task’s inclusion under the objective is seen especially when we come to that solution of it which was set forth above by way of remark (§ 3, Note 3), or even when we merely follow the path taken there; and this principal task has therefore also, in another form, been able and bound to arise in the historical course of philosophy’s development in such a way that the matter was entirely taken up under the pursuit of the objective tasks—namely as the question of the relation between soul and body, and the connected question of the relation between individuality and surrounding world; whereby both question and solution have taken shape in such a way that the task could and had to extend also to plants—indeed to everything that, as a member of the world, stands under the determining influences of a surrounding world, and yet acts out of its own peculiar nature.

Note 2. Here the question arises how far a doctrine such as Locke’s—which aims only at elucidating the fundamental constitution and the source or origin of all cognizing, as it is found to be under exact psychical observation—can be reckoned, both in and for itself and with respect to its effect, not to explicative philosophy alone (under which it straightforwardly belongs), but also to philosophy proper, or speculative philosophy—irrespective, moreover, of what worth and validity we may grant it, on which it here does not depend. —At bottom it aims only at elucidating what I have called the *universam cognoscendi rationem*; but it has come forward as—or at least been made to hold as—that in which not only philosophy’s whole subjective principal task was to find its settlement and quieting, but also the foundation for the question of the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of all things was to be so elucidated that in this respect one could refer

to nothing but empirical inquiry [Empirien]—so that speculative philosophy in the objective respect would thereby be dismissed, and thus the objective principal task, as a speculative task, decided. So far, then, such a philosophy must be regarded as one that has had to do with both philosophy's subjective and its objective task. It has sought, in an all-comprehending way, to set up a fundamental cognition concerning the ultimate grounds of all cognizing, and concerning the way to the finding-out and determination of the ultimate fundamental relations of all things.

Note 3. Concerning a skepticism such as Hume's, something similar is to be noted; but Greek skepticism especially—as that which sprang from the whole course of the fundamental-philosophical movements and bears their stamp—must now be acknowledged as philosophy in the proper sense, insofar, namely, as here, as there, it is only a question of the propaedeutic concept of philosophy that holds for the history of speculative philosophy, and insofar too as a totality of philosophizing that neither leads nor is meant to lead to a philosophical science, but only to the development of a philosophical way of viewing and of taking life, can be called philosophy. —But it is now also seen that the concept of philosophy here given fits that skepticism entirely; for the skeptical doctrine is not that on the empirical standpoint nothing is given that can be assumed with reliability, but that, when one goes to the ultimate grounds, nothing can be set up as incontestably certain—save that skepticism could not, of course, itself come forward as a doctrine, since it had of course to admit that it too must become the object of its own doubt, and so in the last instance dared not come forward as a proper fundamental cognition, wherefore it was to hold only as an ultimate fundamental quieting, aimed at bringing about the ἀταραξία of the mind.

Note 4. When Kant, in order to work toward a similar quieting, sought to establish that there can be question only of a merely subjective reality and validity of all our cognizing, but that such a validity now also stands as firm as can be needful for us—whereas all properly speculative striving would be an attempt at a transcendence beyond all the capacity of our reason—he has thereby not only treated the subjective principal task, but has also sought to settle the objective, namely by cutting it off or dismissing it. —Fichte, on the other hand, in the period when he declared his Doctrine of Science [Videnskabslære] to be only a carrying-through of Kantianism, and could declare it such, went nevertheless, precisely by this carrying-through, so far beyond Kant that he at bottom allowed himself that transcendence, in taking the matter speculatively; for he sought speculatively to clarify and justify the Kantian doctrine by leading it back to a deeper foundation.

Note 5. It must here be noted generally that our determination of the concept of philosophy leaves it undecided whether there are such ultimate grounds of things as can be cognized by us in a rational way. Our conceptual determination therefore holds also for those who, on religious grounds and with regard to positive revelation, reject all philosophy that would venture into the region of the divine; for they do so because they deny that human reason, at least in humanity's fallen state, is capable of pressing through to the highest truths—which is the same as pressing

through to the ultimate fundamental relations of existence. —It must moreover be noted generally that we have not set up philosophy as a doctrine of the ultimate grounds of things, but only as a fundamental cognition that forms itself under a striving to reach the ultimate grounds—that is, a doctrine with respect to them, or concerning them.

§ 11.

Philosophy steps up to what is otherwise given. —A survey of the sum-total of all this.

As that which is to press through to the ultimate grounds and fundamental relations of existence, or of all things, philosophy presupposes that existence, with all it contains, has asserted itself in us, and has been apprehended and is known, and now presents itself as that which philosophy steps up to. Philosophy thus forms itself over against, and in a certain opposition to, both the whole given existence, with what it contains, and the whole body of all that cognizing through which everything that is now to find its ultimate clarification in philosophy antecedently asserts itself in us. Everything that philosophy is thus thought to step up to we call—without, however, meaning to deny that philosophy too can form itself only by being given to us—the sum-total of the Given [Indbegrebet af det Givne], which, moreover, is given us partly in an empirical, partly in an a priori way, and in the latter case again partly in a sympathetic, partly in an intelligent way.

A survey of all this Given will teach us that we have to distinguish therein the following spheres:

1) The domain of outer experience or empirical inquiry [Empirie] (of natural science and human history), in which cognitions form themselves along the way of explicative pursuit, and the first foundation of cognition is observation by means of the outer senses—whether under an immediate becoming-aware or experiencing, or under the apprehension of what others have thus observed and let come to us through so-called transmission (tradition); but the main thing becomes the understanding's penetration into what is thus given, since properly empirical science can consist only in that which is drawn from, or stands out from, the immediately sensed or experienced and the transmitted, with abiding validity and for abiding use.

2) The domain of independent a priori construction or operation, in which we ourselves construct, constitute, produce the objects by an activity that is not reproductive, but aims at realizing thoughts conceived in advance, which then form themselves *a priori*. It is then here this a priori element (the understanding's own inner dictates) that becomes

the object of study. But the a priori element we have to do with here aims as yet only at constituting finite objects and at reflecting on the relations that thereby come forward. —In the mathematical sciences, both pure mathematics and the mathematical-mechanical sciences, we find the greatest and most telling example of such a domain; but examples can also be found elsewhere, for instance in versification and in several spheres of the poetic-aesthetic art, likewise in certain parts of such sciences as do not otherwise belong here—of which syllogistics, grammatical syntax in certain respects, and others, can furnish examples.

3) The domain of inner, psychical observation, which we shall come to call the domain of explicative philosophy.

For the history of philosophy must bring us to distinguish two kinds of philosophy, in that from a) the philosophy proper treated above—which we call the speculative, but may also call the constitutive—we distinguish b) a great body of sciences that have also been called philosophy, and go under that name, although they are only explicative, or each pursue its own certain determinate given in its givenness, without going back to the ultimate grounds of all things, and thus belong under the domain of the explicative sciences, like those named above under No. 1.

To this domain of inner psychical observation, or of explicative philosophy, belong:

a) The domain of inner experience, psychology, in which the objects of our observation and pursuit are our inner states of soul, with all that stirs in them, insofar, namely, as it *de facto* asserts itself (so that there is no question of any ought, anything to be heeded as the all-valid—though certainly the sense for the all-valid, and the human being's relation to it, as it is *de facto* given, must here be taken into account). That part of the considerations belonging here which concerns the way in which all cognition forms itself has especially been called ideology.

b) The domain of mere reflection-philosophy, in which the a priori element that underlies our whole thinking and the pursuit, thereby called forth, of the relations in the world—and so underlies empirical inquiry, as governing and guiding the whole empirical apprehension and pursuit—is observed and explicated in its universal validity or universality (thus also as the valid-for-us). Here, then, in the factual, the universally valid that comes forward therein is studied. To this belong explicative logic and ontology.

c) The domain of explicative philosophy of the Idea, in which the inner manifestations of the infinite and eternal—insofar as they come forward as such, and also show themselves as the higher on which it depends both what we ourselves are to be ensouled and governed by, and by which the goods of life are rightly and thoroughly to

be assessed—become objects of explication and explicative clarification. To this belong explicative philosophy of religion, moral philosophy, and aesthetics.

But if we now look back to speculative philosophy, which is now to step up to all these domains, we note that, since it too has after all asserted itself in the world, and is thus to be found in the world, our speculative philosophizing must also enter into relation to what is thereby given; and so we come to add still:

4) the domain of speculative philosophizing itself, insofar as it is given us in a historical way—that is, the history of philosophy.

Note 1. It has its difficulty to distinguish sufficiently the whole domain of mathematics from the rest of the a priori, so that an essential difference may come to light between mathematics and explicative philosophy. As for the difference of mathematics from speculative philosophy, that is easily seen. Mathematics goes back only to its own ultimate grounds, its own ultimate foundation, and is at every point able to lead everything back to it. But it does not go back to, or seek to go back to, the ultimate grounds of all things, nor to the question of the ultimate ground and groundedness of all cognizing. It has, in general, nothing whatever to do with the tasks of existence itself; it moves only in a realm of possibilities (something it has, moreover, in common with a merely explicative formal logic), and is, of all the sciences, the one that least of all comes into contact with the speculative. —But why is it not reckoned under explicative philosophy? If we consider especially—not geometry, which Kant, as Schmidten notes in his work *Om Mathematikens Væsen*, p. 30, alone seems to have had in view where he would determine the difference between philosophy and mathematics—but arithmetic and algebra, as the theory of functions, then we must acknowledge that it may be asked why mathematics, insofar as it elucidates the nature and essence of calculation, is not just as much to be called philosophical as the explicative logic that elucidates the nature and essence of thinking; especially since calculation, subjectively, both underlies and can come to underlie every exact apprehension of the Given and penetrating cognition therein; and is also, objectively, to be regarded as underlying the whole of existence itself, just as the logical has such an objective reality and existence as foundation for existence; so that, whether explicative logic be counted as philosophy because what it sets out belongs to the general fundamental, or because it explicates the inner a priori in us, there would seem to be ground for reckoning mathematics too as belonging thereto.

Here, then, the following is to be noted. It is given us that mathematics is not reckoned as philosophy, whereas simple explicative logic and ontology, provided they are taken in the right, thorough way, are reckoned as such. This usage, and the view expressed through it, is what we are to clarify by finding out what it is that has made possible its formation. Thus: we are to seek out the difference that may here show itself. And then we might first note that logic and ontology always aim at the more fundamental, the ultimate fundamental; for what they explicate underlies mathematics as well as every other science. It is the direct coming-forward of

an ultimate underlying that is here explicated. This difference, however, could not be enough, since psychology is reckoned wholly to explicative philosophy, although it does not aim wholly at anything generally fundamental. What must become the main point is that the apprehension and observation, and the pursuit of the observed, that take place in the cited domains of explicative philosophy, are to be called psychical, in a sense in which that which occurs in mathematics cannot be so called. For although in mathematics too there is observed what the *a priori* in us has to tell us with respect to the relations that occur and are to be pursued, and the tasks that are to be solved, yet these relations themselves—indeed everything that is observed, that is, the objects of the consideration—cannot be said to be of psychical nature (for the possible application of mathematics in psychology is not here in question). In logic and ontology, by contrast, there are observed partly *consciousness's own facts*, partly the *a priori that constitutes the life of consciousness itself*; whereas, when in mathematics the formula of the parabola is found out, or any function whatever is determined and pursued, this may indeed be said to be something we learn from the *a priori* in us alone, but not something in which this *a priori* is itself observed, nor something that constitutes our own existence of soul. If, on the other hand, someone were to demonstrate the mathematical as a foundation in our reflection on many relations in the world, and even in our life of soul, then this would indeed be explicative philosophy, but would then belong not to mathematics but to psychology.

Note 2. When the all-valid is to be studied in and through the factual, the apprehension of the factual becomes of essential importance in and for the doctrine of the all-valid. This holds especially with respect to explicative philosophy of the Idea, where therefore—although it must throughout come about through one's own observation, so that others' observations are only to be taken as those that are to serve this end—the history of the sciences becomes of a far different and greater importance for the sciences themselves than that which, for example, the history of mathematics can have for mathematicians. But to go so far as to make the whole philosophy of religion consist in the doctrine of religion's historical course of development, as has happened in our time, is not to take the matter rightly.

Note 3. It has, furthermore, its difficulty to distinguish sufficiently between reflection-philosophy and explicative philosophy of the Idea, since in both the all-valid comes forward as such, so that an ought asserts itself just as much in logic as in morals—wherefore Treschow too reckoned logic to practical philosophy (which, in his work *Om Philos. Natur og Dele*, he divided into logic, moral philosophy, aesthetics, and teleology, according to the ends: the true, the good, the beautiful, and the useful). But when one notes that the admonition to respect the logical demands for truth's sake—that is, out of love of truth—is of moral nature, one will see that the ought that arises in logic is only a “so it ought to be,” not a “so *we* ought;” and that former ought is therefore rather a must. —The proper ought expresses a mastery as such, or aims at what is to be ruling in the one governed, when this one shows itself as such—indeed as desiring and willing.

Note 4. That sciences of mixed nature arise, we readily become aware. We have examples of

this in physics and astronomy, insofar as in both the empirical and the mathematical interlock. In psychology, alongside what belongs to the domain of inner experience, that which belongs to the rest of explicative philosophy of the Idea will also come to speech. In aesthetics, under the Idea-philosophical observation and development, one must constantly look to the fundamental aesthetic concepts that have historically asserted themselves. Moral philosophy and philosophy of religion cannot be carried through without empirically given conditions—to which indeed the whole of sinfulness belongs—coming into consideration. —But everywhere the thorough consideration and orientation requires that one be able to become aware of what belongs to each domain.

Note 5. We saw here that psychology takes on a mixed nature by entering upon the domain of the Idea-philosophical. But in yet another respect it shows itself as mixed, since outer observation—namely of others' life and conduct, that is, something belonging to the domain of outer empirical inquiry—must here be taken into account, together with what the inner psychical observation, which becomes the foundation, teaches us. —The philosophy of language, too, must develop itself through a union of empirical study (of the historically given languages) and psychical observation.

Note 6. The philosophy of history is still to be named here as mixed, since in it historical apprehension and pursuit must go in one with an observation that must be of psychical nature. For the philosophy of history is to clarify the whole life-course of humanity with respect to what is to be noted therein in the respect of spirituality, and the development it has taken in that respect. The fundamental moments of the life of humanity, and the course of their movements, are then to be observed; but thus the consideration becomes psycho-biological.

Note 7. We must still direct a special attention to certain sciences that form genuine intermediate links, in that they present genuine synthetic unities of something given in an outer, historical way, and something belonging to the domain of explicative philosophy of the Idea. —What is meant hereby is a) so-called positive revelation and positive theology, and b) positive jurisprudence and politics. In the domain of the first, something that rests essentially on historical transmission is to be brought to live and rule in us, and to ensoul and fill us, in the same way as that in which what belongs to the domain of philosophy of the Idea makes itself both Idea-moving and practically effective in us; and the former must therefore be expounded in a corresponding way. In politics, as well as in the domain of the positive jurisprudence intrinsically belonging to it, there constantly meet—at least as regards so-called administration and the endeavors belonging to the improvement of legislation—the regard for what natural right and the care of the state demand, with the regard for what, in a given state, has partly been positively laid down and thereby set going, partly historically developed; and both what the one and what the other demands in its consequence must be heeded, and a solution of the tasks sought that can at once satisfy in both respects—that is, both in the Idea-philosophical and in the empirical-historical respect.

Note 8. That, finally, explicative and speculative consideration too can be united in one scientific development and presentation must still be noted—of which the present philosophical propaedeutic of ours may be an example.

Note 9. Of a different nature than the sciences of mixed nature discussed so far are the more general sciences, in which that which shows itself as generally underlying in several different domains is separated out and considered by itself in its inner fundamental nature, universally valid for these domains.

Such a science is general biology, insofar as in it the life in plants and animals, the inner life of soul in the human being as individual, and the life in humanity are had in view at once and equally.

§ 12.

Exposition of the given concept of philosophy: three chief points of view herein.

To the sum-total of all that we have called the Given, and have now set out before us in a survey, philosophy steps up—by which, now as hitherto, we constantly mean only the speculative, not the explicative—in order to press through to its ultimate grounds and fundamental relations, and, in force of the cognition of these, to clarify it from the ground up. But since it is thus called forth by the all-comprehending spirit of inquiry that comes into motion in the scrutinizing and grounding subjectivity—which, in order to attain a philosophy, must first philosophize its way to it—philosophy, with respect to the fundamental relation between the true and the subjectivity in which the true is to assert itself, presents itself to us under three chief points of view, namely: I. with respect to the cognizing subjectivity and philosophy's significance for it; II. with respect to the coming-together into unity of the subjective and the objective; III. purely in and for itself, without regard to what stirs in the cognizing subjectivity.

§ 13, a.

Exposition of the concept of philosophy in the first chief respect.

With respect to I. the subjectivity that cognizes and strives after thorough cognition, the spirit of inquiry in motion lets us see philosophy first of all as a) the fundamental cognition that is to proceed from a calling-to-account that goes to the ground, through which everything, each thing severally, is to establish itself for us in the validity it is to have for us, by, as it were, exhibiting its title to assert itself. —But hereby b) everything,

in its whole compass, shows itself as that which presents a problem to be solved; and philosophy has therefore been able to be represented as that which is to solve the riddle of existence, after itself first having let such a riddle arise and take shape for us. —But since to this attaches the remark that the philosophical questions often take the turn of asking after the possibility of that whose actuality no one doubts—indeed whose actuality is perhaps formally established in advance—we see philosophy as that which may be said c) to aim at elucidating the possibility of the actual, which then means explicability, intelligibility, comprehensibility, where actuality and thinking are seen to meet as those that seek a coming-together into unity and a so-called reconciliation—which, however, becomes at the same time a leveling and uniting of the many mutually opposing moments of existence itself, even for the cognizing consideration. —But since, under all such thinking, the spirit of investigation comes into motion as a spirit of discussion or debate, d) philosophy comes forward as that which forms itself in an all-comprehending way in force of overcome dubitation—that is, according to an affirmation in force of overcome negation. (Cf. *Om Erkj. og Gr.*, § 20, p. 162.)

But thus philosophy will present itself to us, on the one side, as that which is to bring the subjectivity to e) a full coming-to-clarity with itself (*Selbstverständigung*, as Jacobi called it), and on the other side as that which is to lead to f) a full coming-to-clarity with the totality in its totality, and thereby to full orientedness within it; from which g) an all-comprehending satisfaction in the domain of cognition must follow.

Note 1. Kant began the whole work of his philosophy (at the beginning of his *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*) with the question: how are synthetic propositions *a priori* possible?—after he had first established the actual existence and reality of such propositions. Later this led to the question: how is a valid cognition possible at all? But this question, with the one lying within it—how is an objectively valid sensation possible?—had already been in full motion in the Cartesian school, in Malebranche and Leibniz, just as it had already fully come forward in antiquity. —How is speculative philosophy possible? we shall come to ask further on. —How is human freedom possible? how is evil possible? are questions that naturally take precisely this form.

Note 2. The nominal concept of philosophy that Fichte gives in the philosophical journal published by him together with Niethammer (year 1797, number 1), as well as the one he set forth in his latest lectures in Berlin, may still be brought to remembrance here. In the former he sets up philosophy as that which is to render the whole of experience explicable by deducing it *a priori*, where then, once philosophy had completed its work, one would have to see whether what it had constructed *a priori* corresponded to experience in such a way that the task could be called solved. Since we possess the whole of experience only in our knowing, he did not thereby deviate from his earlier concept of philosophy, according to which he had given philosophy the name of *Wissenschaftslehre*, as that which was to make the whole of human knowing in its wholeness—as

knowing and the sum-total of knowing in general—the object of explanation. In his latest lectures he stated that every science had its phenomenon—he used precisely this expression—to explain. The phenomenon that philosophy had to explain was now human knowing itself in general, or as a whole, als ein Wißthum. This phenomenon had now first to be expounded, then explained. The former he did in the doctrine *von den Thatsachen des Bewußtseyns*, which came in the first part of his course; —the latter he did in the *Wissenschaftslehre* proper. One easily sees that, in similarity to the way in which Kant began his *Critique*, he could have begun with the question: How is knowing possible at all?

Note 3. We here come to recall the often-mentioned but, as it seems, in our time commonly misunderstood or unknown definition of philosophy that Wolff gives in his *Discursus præliminaris de philosophia in genere* (prefixed to his *Logik*). It runs, in § 29, as follows: *Philosophia est scientia possibilium, qvatenus esse possunt*. Wolff says of it in the note that he first found it in the year 1703, that in the year 1705 he communicated it to the Breslau church and school inspector Caspar Neumann, against whose objections he defended it in a private letter, but that he first made it public in the preface to his *Elementa Aërometriæ*. This, however, does not give the information I had expected to find in it. The meaning of that definition, on the other hand, is sufficiently elucidated in the cited *Discursus* itself—not directly, indeed, but in several ways indirectly. The words on which it especially depends are the last: *qvatenus esse possunt*. In a preceding paragraph (§ 6) *cognitio philosophica* is defined as being *cognitio rationis eorum, qvæ sunt vel fiunt*; and one sees that he regards all rational cognition of that—or all insight into that—which is or happens as philosophical, whereas the mere knowledge of the factual is set up as *cognitio historica*; and the third of the three kinds of cognition he distinguishes, the mathematical, is to aim at the exact determination of finite things by determining their quantitative relations. When he now, in treating more closely this difference between historical, philosophical, and mathematical cognition, says among other things in § 17: *Aliud est nosse factum, aliud perspicere rationem facti, aliud denique determinare qvantitatem rerum*; when in § 7 it reads: *Differt cognitio philosophica ab historica, haec enim in nuda facti notitia subsistit, illa vero ulterius progressa rationem facti palam facit, ut intelligatur, cur istiusmodi quid fieri possit*; and when one now, in the examples he adduces, meets all sorts of phenomena that philosophy is to explain, one sees that his meaning must be that philosophy is to render actuality explicable, by showing how everything in it is able to be. —Later, after that definition of *cognitio philosophica* has been followed by the above-cited definition of philosophy itself, it reads in § 31: *In philosophia reddende est ratio, cur possibilia actum consequi possint*, and immediately after: *In philosophia itaqve reddenda est ratio, qvomodo ea, qvæ fieri possunt, actu fiant*; furthermore it reads in § 32: *qvodsi ergo plura fuerint, qvorum unum perinde possibile est ac cetera, philosophia docere debet, cur illud potius fiat aut fieri debeat, qvam cetera*; on which occasion philosophy is spoken of as *rationes eorum, qvæ sunt vel fiunt, reddens*, and as that which therefore *docere debet, qvænam sit ratio, ut in dato aliquo casu unum potius fiat, qvam alterum*. In § 37 philosophy is named as that *qvæ rationem exponit, cur ea, qvæ*

sunt et fiunt, esse ac fieri possint. In § 46, finally, we find the following definition of a philosopher: *Philosophus est, qvi rationem reddere potest eorum, qvæ sunt, vel esse possunt;* and on this occasion philosophy is named immediately after as that *cujus est rationem reddere, cur possibilia actum consequi qveant, et unum potius fiat in dato casu qvam alterum, qvod perinde possibile erat.* —If one now compares all this, and a good deal more, with that definition—*Philosophia est scientia possibilium, qvatenus esse possunt*—one sees that the weight must fall on the last words, and we see that their meaning must be to indicate what has already been mentioned: that philosophy is to elucidate how everything that *de facto* is found to be, or to happen, in nature (to which, according to § 21, *natura rationalis*, that is, the life of consciousness, also belongs) is able to be—or what its real ground of possibility is. With the actual facts and factually existing things philosophy has nothing to do, insofar as it is a question of which they are; this belongs to historical knowledge; but to elucidate the grounds of them—that is, to show what calls forth or brings about their realization—is philosophy’s task. But that which brings about realization is not actuality itself, but is the real ground of possibility of it. Thus we must without doubt interpret that definition. —Philosophy moves in the domain of the thinkable—there is thinking back and forth—so far we have to do with *possibilia*; but now it is a matter of determining what, out of all this thinkability, rises up as that which has reality and constitutes the underlying element in actuality; which is then not the concrete actual itself, but is that in which the actual has its ground, and from which, accordingly, it is to be discerned how this actual is able to be (*actum consequi possit*). It is thus the realm of the thinkable that meets with that of the actual; the former is to elucidate the latter, the latter is led back to the former and taken up into it. Actuality is here without doubt thought as that which has an inexhaustible realm of possibilities for its foundation—a representation one often meets in the eighteenth century.

§ 13, b.

§ 14.

The Foundation of Philosophy and Its Work.

§ 15.

§ 16.

§ 17.

§ 18.

§ 19.

The Full Determination of the Concept of Philosophy.

§ 20.

Philosophy as a Member and Moment in the Whole Spiritual Life.

§ 21.